

Case Study: Aurelia Motion Systems – Fairness, Ethics, and Accountability

Opening

On a rainy Monday in March 2026, Elena Vogt, CEO of Aurelia Motion Systems, received two messages about the same AI system. The first came from the CFO and asked for stronger accountability: “If NOVA is shaping priorities, we need managers to follow or explain.” The second came from the works council and asked the opposite question: “When does a support tool become a monitoring tool?”

Aurelia Motion Systems was a German automotive supplier with around 1,500 employees. The company produced precision components for thermal management systems, sensor housings, and lightweight assemblies for European carmakers and tier one suppliers. Under strong cost pressure, Aurelia introduced NOVA, an AI supported sales suite that scored opportunities, forecast demand changes, and generated proposal drafts. The system promised faster work and more consistent decisions. It also created new questions about fairness, transparency, privacy, and responsibility.

Six months after the rollout, Elena did not see one obvious scandal. She saw many smaller tensions. A smaller customer complained that its request had been ignored although it was strategically important. Engineering questioned who was responsible for a technically overconfident proposal draft. Sales employees worried that dashboards could be used to evaluate how obediently they followed AI recommendations. Sales Operations could not always explain why a score changed.

Elena asked the external consulting team to prepare a recommendation for the leadership board. “NOVA is not just a tool anymore. It is becoming part of how we allocate attention, justify decisions, and evaluate work. I need a responsible operating concept before we scale this further.”

A short guide to terms used in this case

Term	Plain meaning for this case
NOVA	The name of Aurelia’s AI supported sales suite. It combines forecasting, opportunity scoring, and proposal drafting.
NOVA Forecast	A tool that compares customer schedules, order histories, CRM entries, and market signals to highlight likely changes in demand.
NOVA Signal	A tool that produces customer and opportunity scores. Sales managers use these scores to prioritize requests.
NOVA Quote	A tool that drafts proposal documents by drawing on previous proposals, engineering documents, customer messages, price lists, and margin rules.
Series Sales	The sales team responsible for established products and recurring business with major customers.
New Mobility Sales	The sales team responsible for newer electric vehicle, battery, and sensor related opportunities. Requests are often less standardized.
Sales Operations	The team that maintains CRM data, prepares sales reports, monitors sales process quality, and supports pricing analysis.

From support tool to decision infrastructure

Aurelia introduced NOVA as a support tool. Salespeople were told that final decisions remained human decisions. In practice, NOVA outputs began to shape which customer requests were discussed first, which proposals moved quickly, which assumptions engineering had to review, and which decisions managers later had to explain.

The ambiguity became visible in one New Mobility opportunity. NOVA Quote generated a draft proposal for a battery cooling module. The draft included a delivery assumption based on a previous cooling module project. Sales edited the language and sent the draft for engineering validation. Engineering rejected the assumption and asked for a major revision. The customer had already received an informal signal that Aurelia could respond quickly.

The Head of Sales said: “The tool gives us a draft. Of course humans are responsible.” Sven Richter from Engineering replied: “Responsible for what exactly? If the draft reaches us after the commercial story is already set, we are cleaning up a decision path that already happened.”

The AI program lead added a third position: “NOVA is not autonomous. It supports decisions. But support still shapes decisions. We need to specify where support ends and decision responsibility begins.”

Fairness in customer prioritization

NOVA Signal scored opportunities using expected revenue, margin potential, strategic fit, payment reliability, technical feasibility, and probability of conversion. The score helped sales managers decide which requests deserved senior attention. It also influenced which opportunities entered the weekly leadership dashboard.

Established OEM customers usually had complete records, known interfaces, and stable payment histories. Smaller new mobility firms often had incomplete records, uncertain volume projections, and less familiar technical requirements. NOVA did not explicitly exclude these firms. But low completeness and uncertain history often lowered their scores.

A New Mobility manager warned: “If we use historical completeness as a proxy for quality, we will be fair to the past and unfair to the future.”

One smaller battery systems customer complained after receiving a delayed response. The request had scored low because revenue history was missing and the probability of conversion was uncertain. A sales manager later argued that the customer should have been reviewed because one of its investors had recently signed a strategic partnership with a major OEM. That signal existed in a customer email but had not been entered into the CRM system.

Exhibit 1. Selected records reviewed by the leadership board

Area	Record extract
Customer prioritization	In the top twenty percent of NOVA Signal scores, 78 percent of opportunities came from customers with more than five years of Aurelia transaction history. In the New Mobility pipeline, 46 percent of opportunities lacked complete payment or volume history.
Proposal responsibility	In four New Mobility proposals reviewed after the pilot, engineering reported that technical assumptions appeared commercially mature before validation. Sales replied that all drafts were marked as internal.
Transparency	Salespeople could see main score factors such as margin potential and payment reliability. They could not see the full weighting logic or how some data quality flags changed the score.
Employee dashboard	The dashboard included number of AI alerts handled, average response time to alerts, override frequency, and AI acceptance rate by manager. It was originally built for process improvement, not performance evaluation.
Override comments	Several comments in the override log used short phrases such as “customer special case,” “strategic reason,” or “manager decision.” Sales Operations said these comments were insufficient for learning or accountability.

Transparency and plausible output

NOVA did not usually produce obviously absurd outputs. This made the system harder to govern. Proposal drafts sounded professional. Risk notes appeared balanced. Customer scores came with short explanations. Yet users often could not see how much uncertainty remained behind the output.

Mira Scholz, a proposal coordinator, said: “When NOVA writes a paragraph in confident language, I have to remind myself that it may only be assembling earlier documents. It sounds like it knows more than it knows.”

Sales Operations received many explanation requests. Lena Hartmann said: “Managers ask why the score changed. Sometimes I can point to missing CRM data. Sometimes I can only say which visible factors changed, not how the model weighed them. That is uncomfortable when the score affects attention.”

The vendor offered a standard explanation dashboard but declined to disclose the full model logic, citing proprietary technology and system security. The legal department said this might be acceptable for internal prioritization, but more problematic if scores were used to justify customer treatment or employee performance evaluation.

Employee data and algorithmic control

Aurelia’s leadership board originally promised that NOVA would support salespeople, not monitor them. The distinction became less clear once dashboards showed individual usage patterns. The CFO argued that the company needed to know whether managers used NOVA consistently. The works council worried that the same indicators could become performance measures.

Özlem Kaya, a works council representative, said: “A tool introduced for efficiency can become a tool for behavioral control. If people think every override marks them as difficult, they will stop experimenting and start protecting themselves.”

The CFO responded that accountability was necessary. “If someone ignores the system repeatedly, we need to know why. Otherwise we cannot improve the process.” The Head of Sales agreed in principle but worried about unintended effects. “If acceptance rate becomes a hidden KPI, people will follow NOVA when they should challenge it.”

Elena asked whether Aurelia could distinguish learning data from control data. The AI program lead answered that the dashboard technically could separate team level learning indicators from individual level usage indicators. But the current setup did not yet specify who could access which view, for which purpose, and with what retention period.

Exhibit 2. Extracts from internal messages and interviews

Actor	Extract
CFO	“If NOVA is part of the process, following or overruling it must be visible. Invisible discretion is not accountability.”
Works council representative	“Visibility for learning is different from visibility for control. The current dashboard does not make that distinction.”
Head of Engineering	“When a proposal draft sounds complete, technical responsibility becomes murky. We need to know who owns the assumptions before engineering sees them.”
New Mobility manager	“Some of our most important future customers look weak in historical data. I do not want a fairness rule that treats all uncertainty as poor quality.”
Sales Operations analyst	“We are asked to explain scores, but some explanations stop at the visible factors. That may be enough for process improvement, not necessarily for contested decisions.”

The board discussion

At the March board meeting, the leadership team considered several options. One option was to scale NOVA and handle ethical issues through existing compliance processes. Another was to restrict sensitive dashboard fields until a governance concept was approved. A third option was to continue the rollout but require review rules for proposal drafts and customer prioritization. A fourth option was to pause broader scaling until Aurelia had a responsible AI governance model for sales.

The disagreement concerned proportionality. The CFO warned that a heavy governance process could make NOVA too slow to matter. The legal department warned that vague responsibility could become costly if customers or employees challenged AI supported decisions. The Head of Sales wanted practical rules rather than abstract principles. The works council wanted hard limits on individual monitoring.

Elena closed the discussion with a request for the consulting team: “I do not want a poster about responsible AI. I need operating rules. Who may use which data, who owns which decision, what must be explainable, and where do we draw the line between support and control?”

Your consulting task

You are consultants advising Elena Vogt and the leadership board of Aurelia Motion Systems. Your group focuses on fairness, ethics, and accountability. Your task is not to judge whether AI is generally useful. Your task is to recommend how Aurelia should govern NOVA before scaling it further. Prepare a board pitch. Your pitch should use evidence from the case and end with a concrete concept that the board could adopt. In particular, Elena Vogt is interested in the following questions:

1. What is the central fairness, ethics, and accountability problem created by NOVA? Use evidence from customer prioritization, proposal responsibility, transparency, and employee dashboard data.
2. What should Aurelia do next: scale NOVA broadly, restrict sensitive uses, continue the pilot, or redesign governance before scaling? Justify your choice and discuss the main trade off.
3. Develop a Responsible AI Sales Governance Concept with up to five rules. Specify decision ownership, explanation requirements, limits on monitoring, customer prioritization safeguards, and review rights.

Disclaimer

This teaching case is fictional and intended solely for classroom use. Generative AI has been used to develop this case.